



deployed across five floors. The hotel also invested in five 350-series Access Cards (to be rented out to guests) which, when fitted into the laptop, would enable Internet access. Apart from the rooms, Wi-Fi connectivity is also available at the business and convention centres and at the restaurants. "At our business centre, we provide computers and broadband access to clients who don't carry laptops," says Reddy.

Reddy says that the LAN has been optimised to ensure high speeds and seamless connectivity within the premises and to minimise channel interference. Interactive TV, video-on-demand and video streaming services are on the cards.

'Broadband Is The Key'

Wireless networking enables sharing an Internet connection across a Local Area Net-

work (LAN), without using cables or drilling holes to insert network cables.

Wireless LANs (WLANs) are popular in office environments, where laptop/notebook users can stay connected all the time, even while on the move within the premises—especially in places where a network cord may not be available.

While WLAN deployment was an expensive option a few years ago, today WLANs are being viewed as viable alternatives to cable-based LANs. WLANs are being installed in homes and SoHo environments as well.

In India and abroad, WLANs are extremely popular in offices (Enterprise and SMB), warehouses, hospitals, educational and professional training institutes, airports, and of course, the hospitality industry.

"Enabling connectivity is an integral part of customer service, especially in the hospitality industry. It's no longer a perk, but a necessity," says Varghese M Thomas, Senior Manager, Corporate Communication, Cisco Systems (India and SAARC).

Cisco's offerings in the Indian Wireless market include Linksys systems for the SoHo segment and the Cisco Aironet solutions for the Enterprise segment.

"Not just hotels, but in cities such as Bangalore, Wi-Fi access is available even in studio-houses which are being rented out to business travellers or IT professionals on the move," says Thomas.

There is great potential in India for wireless connectivity, but increased broadband proliferation is the key to its success. Hardware is still expensive here in India, and people need to know that broadband can be used for a lot more than faster data transfer.

"Most business transactions take place online now, and if we have to keep pace with international deals, Small and Medium companies must consider investing heavily in broadband," adds Thomas.

Early last year, the city of Philadelphia in the US, launched a massive initiative to set up the world's largest wireless hot spot spread over 135 square miles of city-space. Placing small transmitters around the city, which could communicate with wireless networking cards, the network would enable citizens to access broadband Internet connection from practically anywhere in the city, free or for a minimum charge.

While Wi-Fi-enabled cities are a distant dream in India, wireless LANs are helping the Indian hospitality industry match its counterparts abroad.

The race to capture the business travellers mindshare has gone high-tech... will WiMAX be the next trump card? ☐

meera_vankipuram@thinkdigit.com

Test your Wi-Q!

- Wi-Fi is an acronym for _____, a widely accepted set of standards for Wireless Local Area Networks (WLAN). The standards pertaining to range of Internet access and transfer speeds.
- According to JiWire.com, there are more than _____ Wi-Fi hotspots around the globe.
- Q3, 2004, saw _____ lead wireless LAN sales worldwide, with nearly 43 per cent market share, according to Synergy Research. Symbol Technologies (15.9 per cent) and Airespace (bought over by Cisco recently) with 5.7 per cent, grabbed second and third places respectively.
- Wi-Fi access points or 'Hot Spots' usually have a range of ____ to ____ feet. Laptop owners require a wireless network interface card (PCMCIA Card) to connect to the Internet.
- Business travellers can find wireless access points across the globe using the online services dubbed _____.



Answers: (a) Wireless Fidelity, (b) 50,000, (c) Cisco Systems, (d) 100,300, (e) Hotspot Locators

Answers